the moment he might feel it is a cruel game, but I was certain the game would take care of him in the future if he continued to serve it the way he had always done.

Finally it was time to leave the stadium. It had been hours since the match had ended and I had not eaten a morsel since breakfast. The Taj management had sent me some haleem (a kind of stew with lentils and meat) and I handed it to Anjali so that we could take it back to the hotel to eat there. As we boarded the bus, Sourav Ganguly, one of my good friends over the years, came to congratulate me one final time. I got off the bus to give him a hug. Dada and I have shared some great moments over the years and have known each other since we were thirteen years old.

Once the bus was on its way to the hotel, Anjali asked me to go and stand next to the driver to wave one final goodbye to the supporters. They were waiting on both sides of Marine Drive and were celebrating and shouting ‘Sachinnn Sachinnn’. We had to pinch ourselves to believe what we were seeing. This was my final send-off and these people, each and every one of them, were making it a fairy tale. I don’t really know what I had done to deserve all this, but it made me feel really blessed to witness these scenes. I was leaving the cricket field with no regrets whatsoever.

An unexpected honour

There was a special reception in the hotel lobby and it was not until 3 p.m. that Anjali and I finally managed some privacy in my room. I took out the haleem that we had brought back and we were both enjoying it and sipping champagne when I received a phone call from the prime minister’s office. I was told that Prime Minister Manmohan Singh wanted to speak to me and after a couple of moments the PM came on the line. He congratulated me on my career and thanked me for serving Indian cricket for twenty-four years. Then he told me that in recognition of my contribution to Indian sport I had been awarded the Bharat Ratna, India’s highest civilian honour.

After I put down the phone, I asked Anjali to stop eating and took her to the table where I had put all my gods and goddesses. We both placed our hands on the table and I told her that she was now looking at a Bharat Ratna. Anjali screamed in delight and gave me a hug. We did not